

along with a combination of skills, talents and spells, the combat system offers a wide variety of options to form a winning strategy during hostile encounters. Spells use the caster's pool of magic energy (or mana) and they come with cool-down timers. Similarly, Talents also have a cool-down timer and they use the character's stamina instead of magic energy. There are also persistent spells and combat skills that reserve a certain amount of mana or stamina respectively.

Another layer of depth is added to the combat system through implementation of spell combinations. Casting spells in a certain order (or combination) will yield additional benefits, like increased damage. It is quite unlikely that you will be able to explore all these possibilities in a single play-through, so this works as an incentive to replay the game.

The specialised classes that you unlock are carried over to all subsequent play-through. This coupled with a better understanding of the game world, combat mechanics, and items, should help you create a stronger, more focused character build from an early stage. A word of caution – the game dictates a greater level of patience and investment of time that we are generally used to.

Some enemy encounters, especially tougher ones may require you to reload the game a few times to rethink your strategy and approach. To slightly digress: the game recorded my total play time at over 60 hours with only 40 percent of game completed! Levelling may thus be perceived as quite slow after the first four or five levels as after spending 60+ hours in the game, my character was just level 20.

This much can be said about the combat system in Dragon Age Origins: those who revel in a tactical approach to encounters will enjoy playing this game.

Origins is unlike any recent Bioware game when it comes to the game's mechanics; it's hardcore.

While the game comes quite close to delivering on its promise of old-school tactical combat; it disappoints on the story front.

New plot, same as the old

The one thing that stood out for me with Baldur's Gate 2 was its main plot – it was both personal and epic. Dragon Age can be summed up as clichéd. It offers the tired storyline of saving the world from imminent destruction. There are instances of déjà vu with the main story and it often feels like old wine in a new bottle. The developers have certainly experimented with presentation and have approached aspects that are RPG staple; the game feels refreshing at that. I believe that with role-playing games, what leaves a lasting impression is your *role* in the game world and how you fulfill that role or achieve your objective.

All the dialogues are spoken, so it spares you from reading reams of text. However, this is hampered by repetitive and irrelevant character animation during conversations. There also appears to be a lack of variety with NPC models as you often encounter characters with striking resemblance to each other.

Technically the game is certainly an improvement for Bioware; however it is not without problems. There are a few quest related glitches and crashes that had me scouring through various discussion forums. The game patch and the official support forums were of little help; thankfully this was offset by active community based forums and wikis.

Conclusively, Dragon Age Origins is a pretty good game; however in its endeavor to succeed Baldur's Gate—it is a battle only half-won.

+ WHAT WE LIKE:

- Deep Combat System
- Variety of strategic options
- Improved party system

- WHAT WE HATE:

- Same old plot
- Frequent crashes

!System Requirements:

Minimum:

OS: Windows XP (SP3), Windows Vista (SP1), or Windows 7
CPU: Intel Core 2 SINGLE 1.6 GHz processor (or equivalent).

RAM: 1 GB (1.5 GB for Vista & Windows 7).

Disc Drive: DVD-ROM drive required.

Hard Drive: 20 GB HDD space.

Video: ATI Radeon x850 256 MB or greater, or NVIDIA GeForce 6600 GT 128 MB or greater.

Vista: Radeon X1550 256 MB; NVIDIA GeForce 7600 GT 256 MB

Sound: Direct X-compatible sound card.



THE SKOAR

Graphics.....8

8

Audio7

Mojo7

Gameplay9